### A Fixed Retrieval Baseline and Its Limits

Synthetic research fixture, not a real publication.

## 1. Baseline design

The fixed baseline selects the same number of notes for every question. This synthetic two-column document represents a contrasting source for the workbench research example.

A fixed retrieval budget does not guarantee relevant evidence.

Irrelevant retrieved passages can increase uncertainty rather than reduce it.

The budget determines how many notes are selected. It does not determine whether those notes address the question or whether the answer accurately represents their contents.

For a fair imaginary comparison, the fixed and adaptive methods share the same question, source collection, and answer length limit. Only the evidence selection rule differs.

## 2. Evaluation notes

A reviewer follows each answer statement back to a selected source. Source identifiers and PDF page indexes are retained with the excerpt, allowing later research notes to show exactly what was checked.

Unsupported detail must remain distinguishable from supported detail. A plausible sentence without matching evidence cannot become a reliable conclusion merely by being repeated.

The column layout is intentional. It verifies that reading and selecting text works for ordinary multi-column PDF material in addition to the single-column companion fixture.

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## 3. Failure condition

Irrelevant sources can leave retrieval-based answers unsupported.

The imaginary failure condition places unrelated notes in the corpus. The baseline still retrieves the fixed number of notes, but those notes cannot establish the requested claim.

Increasing the evidence count alone does not resolve this failure. The research question and the source excerpt must concern the same claim before the excerpt can support a useful answer.

These statements are authored examples, not measurements. They support a controlled software test of comparing two pieces of evidence and preserving qualifications in a conclusion.

## 4. Research use

Use this source as a limitation card alongside the adaptive retrieval card. The board can connect the two card placements with a relation such as condition or limitation.

A complete export should identify this fixture, its authors and year, the PDF page containing the excerpt, and the exact quote. It should not claim to include the original PDF unless the export actually contains it.

Suggested synthetic citation: Read-paper fixture authors (2026). A Fixed Retrieval Baseline and Its Limits. Self-authored software test material; not a real publication.